

Seawall height in Delray Beach

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

DELRAY BEACH • PALM BEACH COUNTY

4.2 ft NAVD88 minimum

Delray Beach sets one minimum in every flood zone, 4.2 ft NAVD88, and lets the maximum vary with your flood zone. The rule applies when a seawall is built, substantially repaired, or has fixed structures attached to it. Build below 5 ft and the wall must still be engineered so it can be extended to 5 ft later.

The detail

MINIMUM, EVERY FLOOD ZONE	4.2 ft NAVD88; Table 7.1.7(D) applies the same minimum to all three flood-zone rows.
WHEN IT APPLIES	New tidal flood barriers, substantial repair or rehabilitation of shorelines and shoreline structures, and installing fixed infrastructure attached to a barrier, such as docks or mooring structures. The applicability sentence ends with the words on the Intracoastal Waterway, so ask the city how it reads that for a canal lot. LDR 7.1.7(B).
MAXIMUM, BFE 5.0 FT OR HIGHER	The base flood elevation of the property, from the FEMA map.
MAXIMUM, BFE OF 4.0 FT	5 ft NAVD88.
MAXIMUM, X ZONE OUTSIDE THE FLOODPLAIN	Must meet the definition of grade in Section 4.3.4(J)(2).
BUILD LOW, ENGINEER HIGH	A wall built under 5 ft NAVD88 must be designed and constructed to accommodate a future extension to at least 5 ft.
WHAT COUNTS AS SUBSTANTIAL REPAIR	Work on more than 50% of the length of the structure, cap included, or any work changing the elevation along more than 50% of the length. Then the whole shoreline must meet the minimum.
SELLERS MUST DISCLOSE	Under LDR 7.1.7(D)(7), any contract to sell property in a tidally influenced area of Delray Beach, signed after 1 February 2022, must carry a tidal-flood-barrier disclosure in bold capitals of at least 14 point.

Where this comes from: City of Delray Beach Land Development Regulations Sec. 7.1.7 and Table 7.1.7(D); Ordinance 23-21, adopted 11 January 2022

Verified: 2026-09. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.